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Albertnative 2025

The Budge Project Submission

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Resolving the lack of financial literacy among the French youth

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November 4th, 2025

1. Context and Problem Definition

In France, financial literacy remains remarkably low, especially among young adults. For many, money is still seen as a taboo topic. In our group, we have all witnessed situations where people refuse to discuss this topic openly. As a result, most young people finish their studies and start their active life without a clear understanding of how to budget, save, or invest effectively. For example, in 2023, the Banque de France reported that 64% of 15–17-year-olds want to better understand savings and investment, and that 81% of French adults believe financial education should start at school. The same Banque de France (see Appendix 2 for the digits) release shows only 56% of French adults achieve at least a "basic" financial knowledge score, underscoring the education gap the public perceives. At the same time, inflation has sharply eroded purchasing power over the past few years. Many 18–30 year olds leave their savings idle on a *livret A* or current account, losing value each year without realizing it. They are aware that their money "isn't growing," but they lack the knowledge, tools, or confidence to take control of it. In that case, we believe a data-driven and AI-based approach will make financial education more personalized and effective. By analysing user behaviour and knowledge gaps, AI will adapt lessons, simplify complex concepts, and deliver the relevant content at the right moment, making learning both ergonomic and engaging.

2. Market and Tech Watch

Market size and momentum

Globally, the financial wellness market (which includes financial education) was $3.8 billion in 2024 and is projected to reach $10.2 billion by 2034, a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 10.4% over 2025–2034. In Europe, the financial wellness benefits segment was $645.36 million in 2024 and is expected to grow at a CAGR of 12.5% during 2024–2031. In France, the financial wellness benefits market was $59.37 million in 2024 with a projected CAGR of 11.7% over the same forecast period. All these digits, coming from Cognitive Market Research (see Appendix 2), indicate market growth in the coming years, both in France and at the European level.

Global benchmark

We conducted a global scale benchmark (see Appendix 1. Benchmarking personal finance apps, education apps included) of existing financial apps to identify what works and what doesn't. In addition to simply considering financial education apps, we decided to expand our benchmark to other personal finance apps, as they often include an educational component, and also because, admittedly, it's hard to find open source data for the specific market of financial education apps. Tools like Bankin', Wallet, and YNAB help users track spending, but their focus is purely transactional and not really educational. On the other side, Zogo, Banqer, and Your Juno offer financial learning experiences, but they target specific audiences (students, women, or Gen Z in the US or UK) and lack a strong presence in France.

Main competitors in the French personal finance market

Bankin' is the French pioneer in budgeting and bank-account aggregation, claiming over 6 million users across France, the UK, Spain and Germany. Bankin' automates expense categorisation and offers savings suggestions via a "Coach" function, but its offering is still largely transactional and lacks a strong educational or gamified learning path for financial literacy.

Finary is a French fintech platform that aggregates savings, investment and banking accounts, targeting users who seek a consolidated wealth-view. It recently reported serving 650 000 users in France. Finary offers advanced tracking tools and uses AI for categorisation, but its core focus remains on wealth management (bank accounts + investments) rather than pedagogical content or gamified learning.

Thus, we have seen that competition focuses on wealth aggregation or investment. Finary and Bankin' provide detailed dashboards but little behavioral support. There, we see a clear market gap. Most personal finance apps are intimidating for beginners. Dashboards full of charts and acronyms make users feel less confident, not more. We want to reverse that experience. No solution combines financial learning, gamification, and local relevance for French users. No major app transforms savings management into an educational game. Furthermore, none of them seem to take advantage of AI tools, beyond anecdotal features such as categorization in Finary.

3. Ideation and Value Proposition

To find solutions, we had two brainstorming sessions and centralized all our ideas in a Notion folder. After that, each of us listed the key points we found most important. Then, during a final debate session, we compared and discussed them to define the project's overall direction and core features. We all have quite different areas of expertise, so it was interesting to compare our points of view because we were able to see the depth of the different aspects of the same problem. We decided to focus exclusively on young adults aged 18–30 in France, a segment that is digitally native, yet financially unprepared. While older audiences may have more wealth, this younger generation is easier to reach and more open to learning through interactive digital experiences. Our value proposition is simple but ambitious:

"Make financial literacy accessible, engaging, and enjoyable for the French youth."

To tackle this cultural issue head-on, we will create a financial education companion that helps young French adults understand how money works in a fun way. For the moment, we decided to name it *The Budge*. In English, to budge means to make a small movement, and we think progress doesn't come from big overnight changes, but from tiny shifts and consistent habits that move us forward. Therefore, *The Budge* aims at changing habits step by step. In our vision, solving France's financial literacy gap starts with an innovative approach to education. That's why our method will combine neuroergonomy, gamification, and actionable insights, with AI playing a central role in personalization, user engagement and to make knowledge easier to digest.

The app will be built around three key pillars:

1. **The Academy** will be an interactive learning hub with gamified paths. Users will earn XP points, rewards or badges for completing lessons and challenges. A streak system, monthly events, and a league ranking will keep engagement high and churn low.
2. **The Newsletter** will provide personalized financial updates powered by LLMs, adapting to each user's situation and interests.
3. **Budgeting Insights** will offer a simple overview of spending patterns, not to manage money directly, but to contextualize learning and encourage responsible habits.

Inspired by Duolingo's juicy design philosophy, we will focus on bright colors, a friendly mascot, and a "learn by play" experience. We will pay particular attention to user feedback in order to adapt our app to their needs and suggestions. The more users learn, the more the app evolves with them, encouraging them to take the next step in their financial journey, one small lesson at a time.

4. Proposed Solution (Concept)

The Budge will first launch as a mobile application centered on education, not account aggregation. The main feature is going to be *The Academy*. It will offer progressive learning paths that mix theory and practice. Example lessons include:

- *What are stocks, what are ETFs and why they matters,*
- *How inflation affects your savings,*
- *Understanding financial crises and what they teach us,*
- *How to handle taxes and everyday money tips.*

Each module will be based on learning principles such as the Ebbinghaus curve and the Dunning-Kruger effect. They will be short, intuitive, and playful, using interactive quizzes and real-life examples. We will train a retrieval augmented generation (RAG) model through Vertex AI to ensure that all educational content is accurate, drawn from our own corpus that we will have selected, and to minimize hallucination risks. Our model will make learning more ergonomic and effective by dynamically adapting content difficulty, recommending the most relevant next lesson, and identifying where users may struggle.

The second core feature is the personalized newsletter, powered by LLMs through Vertex AI. It will automatically summarize financial news and regulatory changes relevant to each user. For example, if a user owns an apartment in Paris, they'll be notified of changes in housing tax policies. If they have frequent Uber or fashion-related spending, they'll receive alerts about lifestyle budgeting or sustainability. This AI-powered personalization engine will never provide financial advice, only contextual education and responsible information.

Finally, an optional budget view will give users feedback on their habits, enabled by APIs like Powens for account integrations. If time allows it, we want to add an ML layer to detect behavioural patterns, for instance, spikes in certain categories of expenses or recurring monthly trends, and translate them into practical learning prompts within the Academy. However the

training data will be limited. We were unable to find such datasets in open source so we are considering creating our own data samples from our own bank accounts, evaluating our habits. This feature will remain limited during the MVP phase to avoid regulatory constraints and technical overload.

5. Feasibility and Implementation Plan

Team Composition

- **Charles DAUMESNIL** - *KPMG* Data Project Manager
  He will be the Project Leader, ensuring that the various talents within the team are coordinated. He will also be the Sales & User Acquisition Lead, in charge of marketing and partnerships.
- **Pavel-Dan DIACONU**- *AI Partners* Consultant
  Daily working with automated workflows and AI tools, he will serve as a Data Engineer, responsible for Google Cloud tools, data pipelines, and AI model integration.
- **Vincent LAMY** - *Total Energies* Data Analyst
  As a premium user of the Finary app himself and with experience in investing, he will be our Financial Expert, curating and validating all educational content. He's also eager to leverage different GCP features.
- **Alexandre WAERNIERS** - *Synchrone* Data & AI Developer
  He will be our Mobile Developer, designing and coding the front-end app. He will also contribute to the management of potential data pipelines through GCP.

Together, our team covers financial, business and technical aspects. We will collaborate closely focusing on quick iterations and user feedback.

Technical Feasibility

Our infrastructure will be built on the Google Cloud stack. Firebase will be used for user authentication, secure data storage, analytics, and synchronization across devices, ensuring a seamless learning experience on both mobile and web. Vertex AI will power the personalization engine by managing and deploying a machine-learning model that adapts dynamically to user progress. We will generate and personalize educational content and newsletters at scale with Gemini 2.5 Flash because it is best for large scale processing, low-latency, high volume tasks. Our data pipelines will run through BigQuery for large-scale analytics and behavioural pattern detection—identifying where users engage most and where they lose interest. Cloud Run will host the modular services that connect the front-end app to our AI systems, allowing fast, serverless deployment and automatic scaling. Finally, Dialogflow will be explored to create an optional conversational assistant or voice-based tutor, making the learning process even more interactive thanks to speech-to-text. Our mobile interface will be developed with Flutter, providing a lightweight, responsive front-end that aligns with our goal of making financial learning intuitive, ergonomic, and engaging. All components will remain fully compliant with AMF regulations, as our platform will provide only educational insights, never investment recommendations or financial advice.

Timeline

Phase	Objective	Deadline
MVP Submission	Working prototype with first educational features	December 14
Go-to-Market Strategy	Market fit + Responsible AI plan	January 15
Beta Version	Stable version with AI newsletter and improved UX	February 13
Demo Day	Live pitch and demo	February 27

We will use November and December to build and test the MVP. January and February will be dedicated to user testing, performance monitoring, and UX refinement.

Risks and Limitations

We have limited time and budget to train or fine-tune models, so if we see our RAG model is not concluding, we will rely on pre-built Google solutions to ensure reliability. Moreover, there is some regulatory uncertainty regarding the boundary between financial education and advice, which means we must be extremely cautious and ensure full compliance with AMF regulations from the very beginning of the project. Finally, the project's scope is ambitious for a four-month student timeline, so we will develop features progressively and in order of priority: first the Academy, then the Newsletter, followed by the Budgeting module, and eventually the Dashboard overview if time allows. To mitigate these risks, we plan to keep our MVP narrow but functional, prioritizing user experience and feature depth instead of adding lots of features and spreading our efforts thin.

6. Conclusion and Next Steps

Our immediate goal is to deliver a solid MVP by December 14, showcasing a working version of *The Budge Academy* and the AI-powered newsletter. We are excited to reach the user testing and feedback phase in early 2026, where we can refine the product based on real user behavior. Beyond the hackathon, we see potential for future development by integrating dashboards for broker and crypto accounts, expanding the learning catalog, and partnering with banks or educational institutions. At that point, compliance work will need to be done to obtain certification from the AMF. While our technical skills and time are limited, our ambition is not. We are passionate about solving a deep cultural problem: the lack of financial literacy in France. And we believe we can go beyond existing solutions in personal finance through an engaging product experience and leveraging the full potential of AI tools. In the end, *The Budge* will be more than an app: it is going to be a cultural shift, changing how young people in France learn and live with money.

Appendix 1. Benchmarking financial education apps and budgeting apps

Apps	Category	Country of origin	Main Target	Size	Comments
Bankin'	Budgeting	France	European individuals seeking to better manage their finances	6 M downloads (both App Store + Android)	• Strong presence in Europe • Freemium model • Funded through partnerships and provides a budget coach
Finary	Savings overview, investing, education	France	French people interested in investing	• 650 000 downloads • Recently raised €25 M in serie C funding	• Super-app combining savings overview, financial products, budgeting, forum • Vulgarization through a Ytb channel • The Finary Plus subscription costs €149.99/year or €24.99/month.
Wallet	Budgeting	Czech Republic	Users wanting to track expenses and income across Europe	+10 M downloads	• Multilingual app (19 languages) • Freemium model
YNAB (You Need A Budget)	Budgeting	USA	Users wanting to structure their budgets	• 10 M monthly visitors • $ 49 M/year revenue	• Paid app ($109/year) • Strong reputation in the US
Intuit Mint	Budgeting	USA only	General public, all experience levels	25 M historical users	• Service was discontinued in 2024 • Former free market leader in the US
Qapital	Budgeting/ Saving	USA	Individuals seeking to automate their savings	• 2 M users • Raised $ 55 M over 6 rounds on the 2013- 2024 period	• Rule-based savings automation • Popular US concept

Zogo	Financial Education	USA only	Young / Gen Z learning finance through games	100 000 to 600 000 downloads (couldn't find more precise)	• Short learning modules, rewards • Banking partnerships
Ellevest	Education/ Investment	USA	Women seeking to invest and improve financial literacy	100 000 registered clients	• Female-focused fintech • Subscription model ($9/month)
Your Juno	Financial Education	UK	Women and non-binary people in Europe	65 000 downloads	• Inclusive positioning • Free app
Banqer	Financial Education	New Zealand /Australia only	Primary/secondary schools	15 000 students	• Educational app for schools only • Financial simulator

Appendix 2 - Sources

Banque de France - La culture financière des Français s'améliore progressivement d'après de nouvelles études menées par la Banque de France

https://www.banque-france.fr/fr/communiques-de-presse/la-culture-financiere-des-francais-sameliore-progressivement-dapres-de-nouvelles-etudes-menees-par

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